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Mind Over Matter

I spent my whole ride home sweating every little detail of our evening on the town, but it was nothing but wasted effort. Every worry I quelled had another one waiting behind it in a never-ending sequence.

I showered, blow-dried my hair, then dug into the back of my closet and pulled out an informal dress. Teal, with an understated floral pattern, in a style a designer would call *A-line*. Fun and flirty, with a high scoop neck, it offered no obvious hints at anything more. The kind of dress my father would have narrowed his eyes at, but then let me wear without comment.

I had bought it on a whim a while ago, thinking it was perfect first date material. Despite my numerous concerns about tonight, I had to admit it was nice to see the dress being put to use before the moths ate it.

It was only a few minutes after seven when my doorbell rang. No surprise there. Fashionable lateness didn't really seem like a concept Danni would be big on.

I tossed Tramp a biscuit to distract him, then wondered why my heart was hammering in my chest as I reached for the door.

What I found on the other side didn't help.

Danni's simple, belted one-shoulder dress featured a high neck line and a hem that fell only a few inches above her knee. While the open shoulder revealed much of her upper body, the look qualified as modest under any modern sense of the word. It was pretty and fun without being overtly sexual, and she looked sensational in it.

But, for some reason, I saw more.

I got hung up on things like the way the peach tone looked so perfect against her tan skin, and how the fit subtly accentuated every curve and nuance of her trim, toned body.

I wanted to speak, but couldn't come up with a damn thing to say. My mind swam with thoughts and worries about what the dress meant, where this was headed and whether I could live up to what she was expecting.

If my torment was apparent, Danni didn't acknowledge it.

"Wow... you look terrific!" she said.

Her tone of surprise snapped me out of my stupor.

"Are you saying I don't usually look terrific?"

"Not at all," she said.

Again, there was something in her tone. A little too earnest, this time.

"After all," she continued, "you just said it, so why do I need to repeat it?"

"You're hilarious," I said.

She smiled, then went quiet. As if she were waiting for something.

Oh... right.

"You don't look half-bad, yourself," I said quickly.

She smiled and thanked me, but I knew it had taken too long, and the words came out flat.

Not even out the door, and I was already disappointing her.

She didn't let it show as she gestured toward the Audi and said, "Shall we?"

"Absolutely," I said.

We got in and, as always, I was briefly taken by the vehicle's interior. Sleek, modern and seamless, it was every bit as gorgeous as it's driver.

Wait... what? Did I just compare Danni to the car? Am I crazy?

Unfortunately, the drive to Long Branch took a little over half an hour, and the vehicle's design wasn't distracting enough to fill that much time. Again, my mind started to run away with me. Before long, I realized Danni was talking and I was only half-listening. I tried to focus, but it didn't do much good. It was like the pressure I'd been feeling had taken on a physical quality, and I was too preoccupied with pushing back against it to give attention to anything else.

It was the same at dinner. Danni was talking and I was trying to keep up my end, but the conversation seemed to die every time I spoke. Probably because whatever I said revealed that I wasn't actually paying attention.

Meanwhile, my thoughts became a constant stream of reminders of just how obsessed I was with how this night was going to end.

The lights in here are so dim, it's practically dark. How do her eyes shimmer like that?

The waitress floated in and out of the scene. Courses came and went.

How did I never notice how flawless her skin is?

Twice, I realized I had just repeated something I'd said only moments before.

How did she manage to find a dress that fits her so well? It looks like it was molded onto her.

It wasn't so much that I was out of control as I simply didn't feel present. We had been out together countless times and knew each other like no one else, yet I just couldn't seem to get in sync with what was going on. Danni looked and acted no differently than usual, but every minute felt alien to me. Like I was watching instead of participating.

As the waitress took our plates away, I realized I didn't even know what I'd eaten.

All the while, I kept thinking, *Can I do this? SHOULD I do this? Will she be disappointed if I don't?*

I mean, Danni looked good, right? No... she looked GREAT. So great, I hadn't been able to think of anything else all night. So, what was the problem?

The check came, and we split the bill. At least, I think we did. I just put my credit card in the little holder with hers. I'm not really sure what happened after that.

As we left, I could feel my muscles tightening. The moment of truth was drawing near.

I told myself that maybe I was wrong. Maybe we'd just end the night as always, and I would go home and laugh at myself for being so stupid.

Then Danni gestured down the boardwalk and said, "Wanna take a walk?"

My body stiffened and I almost fell over.

Pretty dresses, an expensive dinner and now a romantic moonlight stroll.

Seemed we'd checked all the boxes, except one.

I nodded dumbly and drifted in the direction she'd indicated.

At one point in history, Long Branch served as the 'summer capital' of the country. It was here that President Grant stayed for three months each year as he oversaw the post-Civil War reconstruction of the nation. However, there is no marker or other indication of the presence of one of the most important Americans in history. Instead - in a tribute only the Jersey Shore could manage - the site of Grant's former cottage is nothing more than a grassy plot between two rows of parking spaces.

The city fell a long, long way from its heyday, bottoming out as the depressed, run-down area I remember from when I was a kid. But the past decade or so has seen a significant rebirth, if only here by the water. The centerpiece of the rejuvenation is this gorgeous new boardwalk - which even included a way-too-late statue of Grant in an effort to recapture a little bit of the glory days. It's all surrounded by pricey luxury apartments stacked above expensive eateries and high-end storefronts, with everything painted in pretty

pastel colors. The overall effect is absolutely picturesque, and the developers would be thrilled to hear that this is one of my favorite places to while away a summer evening.

They would be less excited to know that I can't bring myself to even step into any of the shops, for fear that I will immediately start yelling at someone over the ridiculously inflated prices. This evening's events aside, I generally avoid the restaurants for much the same reason. Instead, I come and enjoy the sights and sounds at no expense, then hop in the car and head inland for whatever I'm craving. Fifteen minutes north to the Willow Deli for a sandwich, or south to Pete and Elda's for a thin crust pie. Or I can just walk off the southern end of the boardwalk for a chili dog at Max's.

What can I say? I'm a no-frills kind of girl.

We walked for a while in total silence. Though the autumn months had officially arrived, the warmth of the day lingered and the breeze was light. Just enough to make her dress flutter gently against her skin, pulling in all the right places.

God... she DOES look terrific.

She caught me looking and some sort of recognition washed over her face. Embarrassed, I quickly turned away.

A few moments later, she nudged me right and steered us toward the ocean. We stopped side-by-side against the rail, listening to the waves crash against the shore. After a few moments, Danni inched closer, and I felt the heat of her hand on my back. I gripped the rail tightly with both hands, letting it steady me.

I was really starting to think I couldn't do this.

Then she eased herself behind me and wrapped her arms around my waist.

Uh, oh... here we go...

She leaned close and took my earlobe between her lips. I felt the tip of her tongue gently run along the edge, and I fought like hell not to flinch.

"You really need to calm down," she whispered.

Huh?

I turned my head until her face came into view and saw she was smiling from ear to ear.

"Aww, goddammit..." I moaned, as I pushed her away with my elbow.

She went back to the rail beside me, laughing openly.

For a while, I didn't say anything. Allowing myself the proper amount of sulking over the way she'd abused my fragile emotional state.

"Was I that obvious?" I asked eventually.

"It was obvious that you were losing your mind," she said, "but I didn't know why until I caught you staring at my boobs."

I looked away as I felt the heat rise in my cheeks.

"Ah, geez..." I mumbled.

She reached down and took hold of my hand, but didn't say anything. Giving me time to get over my embarrassment while letting me know there was nothing to be embarrassed about.

"I owe you an apology," she said after a while.

"Yeah," I responded. "You licked my ear."

She laughed again.

"Fine. Two apologies."

She waited for me to face her before she went on.

"I didn't mean for this to happen," she said. "I just wanted to do something a little different. I thought it would be fun. The last thing I wanted was for you to stress out over it."

I shook my head and blew out a long, frustrated sigh. With the pressure of my fears gone, it was easy for me to see how badly I'd misjudged everything and how big a mess I'd made.

"You didn't do anything," I admitted. "There's nothing wrong with different. I'm the one who turned it into... whatever this was."

She didn't respond to that. Probably because there was nothing to say. This had been all me, and we both knew it. I was struggling with the nature of this relationship, and I let those struggles color everything that happened tonight. All she did was ask me out on a date. Something I said very clearly I wanted during our reconciliation in Louisiana. And I took that simple, sweet gesture and morphed it into something approaching a nightmare.

But maybe the evening hadn't been a total disaster. Though my technique left much to be desired, here we both were, with the questions that had been tormenting me now out in the open. It gave me the chance to act on the one thing Emma had said that made sense to me.

"I think we need to talk," I said.

"That sounds like an excellent idea," she said warmly.

So, we did. Or, mostly, I did. I went through what I'd been feeling, and the confusion I couldn't seem to get past. I told her how much I cared about her, and how badly I wanted to meet whatever expectations she had. And that's where she stopped me.

"I don't have expectations," she protested. "I don't feel that way, at all."

"I'm not saying you have a checklist of requirements I need to meet. But... you want this, right?"

"This?"

"This thing. This... pull. Whatever you want to call it. Part of being in love like this... there's supposed to be a physical attraction, right?"

"Yeah, but..."

"I know, I know," I interrupted. "You're not putting expectations on me. But what about you? Do you feel it?"

The question caught her short, and now she was the one who flushed. She turned away and spent a long, quiet moment looking out at the water.

"You understand what you're asking me to say, right?"

That's when it occurred to me that, no... I really hadn't thought about what I was asking.

I've been in quite a few relationships over the years with a number of different people. Some were serious. Most were short. Regardless, I had never asked any of them to stand in front of me and openly declare they were attracted to me.

What I was doing to Danni now was unfair.

"Yeah, OK. It's a weird question. But that's my point. It's weird because it's not something you normally have to ask. And the truth is, I'm not really asking you because I know the answer."

"Oh yeah?" she smiled. "How do you know that?"

"Same as with anyone else," I said seriously. "I can feel it. And that's the problem because I know you're not feeling it from me."

"That's not completely true," she said.

"What do you mean?"

"This relationship... it's very different, in all kinds of ways," she said. "We're co-workers. We've been friends for a long time. And yes, we're both women. It's a lot to adjust to. These are things I don't think either of us has ever experienced before."

I nodded steadily. Though I'd been focused on the strangeness of a same-sex relationship, there was no question there were many factors that were influencing my emotions. As Emma had alluded, the way this had all happened was completely backwards compared to any other relationship I'd been in. So, it wasn't that surprising that I didn't know how to navigate it.

Danni's words also reminded me that I was not the only one who had never been intimate with another woman.

"But despite all that," she continued, "we're trying. Even tonight... the fact that you were so worried... it means something. You're struggling with everything, but you're trying. That's what I feel from you, and that's all I care about."

I thought long and hard about what she was saying. Just trying didn't feel like enough after all this time, but maybe it was. Maybe continuing to put the effort in was all that mattered.

"You don't sound like the woman who let herself get distracted by many of these same questions a few months ago."

"I'm not," she said.

Clear and definitive, her words didn't require explanation. I still didn't know how she'd become so sure, but I liked the sound of it. Because it turns out that, despite what I've been telling myself, there is still a part of me that worries about a repeat of what happened last time. But seeing and hearing her like this told me that wasn't going to happen.

It also allowed me to be honest. Both with Danni and with myself. I knew I would say things I didn't mean and try to force myself to feel things I didn't feel if I thought she needed it. But those would be short-term solutions that would probably do more damage than good.

If I was ever going to truly have those feelings, I needed them to come naturally. Danni was giving me the strength I needed to let that happen.

"OK," I said.

"That's it? Just OK?"

"It's all I've got, right now," I said. "I'm sorry about the way I acted tonight. I feel like a fool."

"I'm kinda used to that."

I pushed another elbow into her, and she swayed with the light blow but didn't retaliate.

Then, just for the sake of clearing the ledger, she said, "I'm sorry I licked your ear."

That made me laugh despite how stupid I felt, which is something she's pretty much always been able to do for me. Moments like that were exactly the reason I was trying so hard to make this work. Now, apparently, I was going to have to work hard at not trying so hard.

I also got to thinking that the moment was funny, but also interesting... and not exactly in a good way.

Why did I cringe the way I did? Did it really bother me, or did I just react that way because I was wound up like a clock spring?

Be open to it, Emma had said. Be willing to let it happen.

I had earned no points in that category. Though Danni had only been messing with me, I hadn't know it at the time. Had she been serious, how would that have turned out? No doubt, it would have been a disaster because I hadn't been open to anything.

I didn't feel like having my scorecard of failure peer reviewed right then, so the conversation ended there. After a few minutes, Danni edged a little closer. Then I felt her hand on my back again. It was warm and soothing, and it came with a painful stab of humiliation at the wave of panic that same touch had caused only moments ago.

This time, I turned into her and let her pull me close.

"I'm sorry," I said again.

I turned my head to look up at her and there was that smile again. This time, the sight of it made my heart lighter. Then I realized it was the first time she'd smiled that way since she'd picked me up. She had planned on a quiet, enjoyable evening that should have given her plenty of reason to smile, and I had ruined it with my ridiculous worrying.

"What are you doing tomorrow night?" I asked.

She shrugged and said, "Probably the same thing you're doing."

"I want to try this again."

She looked down at me with a funny grin. Like she knew what was going through my head, and she was amused by how urgently I wanted to make up for my failure.

"I think I've had all the blackened salmon I can eat, for a while."

"We'll take it down a notch," I said. "How about Illiano's?"

Running the gamut from pizza to veal picata, Illiano's was exactly as Italian as it sounded. Just saying the name out loud put visions of pasta, basil, garlic and prosciutto in my head.

"Oh, yeah," she deadpanned, "because penne vodka is SO much lighter than salmon."

I smiled at that, then waited for her real answer.

"It sounds fun," she said. "Shall I pick you up at the same time?"

"I'll pick you up this time," I countered. "Earlier. Around five."

"That's a little early, isn't it?"

"I want to have time to enjoy the company I'm keeping."

She gave me the knowing smirk again.

"Five it is, then."

We stood in silence for a while, and I spent the time marveling at how much my mood had changed since leaving the house. It was a turnaround made possible by the way Danni had dealt with things. It couldn't have been easy to hear me say I wasn't feeling the same attraction she clearly was, but she had put her focus on making me feel comfortable rather than dwelling on the negative.

And now... now I was feeling a little pull of some sort. Some magnetic force that seemed to be coming from her. Like I needed to be in her orbit, rather than just wanting to be there.

When the evening chill settled in and finally forced us back to the car, I took another moment to appreciate it's impressive styling. Then Danni pushed the ignition button, and the satisfying rumble of the engine coming to life reminded me that the car not only looked good, but also had the strength and ability to handle almost anything without breaking a sweat.

I looked over to Danni and thought that maybe my earlier comparison hadn't been so ludicrous, after all.